



INTRODUCTION

by Stan Lee

It just had to happen! There have been so many new and exciting developments in the Marvel Universe that fans world-wide have been clamouring for this second edition.

That's why we've totally updated everything by adding Marvel's mind-bending crossover developments such as Annihilation! Civil War! The Secret Invasion/Dark Reign! Private Hulk/World War Hulk!

Nor have we neglected new characters and updates on old ones. Here is just a tip of the incredible iceberg: Anti-Venom, Captain Midlands, Hulkling, Sabreclaw, Spider-Man 2211, Venus.

And, of course, we've included new teams, such as Agents of Atlas, Serpent Squad, X-Cell, Young Avengers.

And that's why I still proudly say—It ranks way up there with the discovery of fire and the invention of the wheel. Just like them, it represents an epic milestone in the history of the human race. That's why I'm so incredibly proud to be writing this intro for a book that mankind has been hungering for, a book that is—now and forever—a shining beacon of wonder, a titanic tribute to talent unleashed, with the simple but awesome title of—*The Marvel Encyclopedia*.

Here you'll find more than a thousand of Marvel's classic characters, all brilliantly illustrated, with their lives and vital statistics laid bare for your closest scrutiny and your browsing delight.

On a personal note, I must confess, when I first dreamed up some of the more prominent characters you'll find in this volume, I never dreamed that decades later they would have achieved the fame and popularity which they now enjoy. It's almost impossible to describe the feeling of pride, mixed with disbelief, that I feel when I realize how many great movies, video games, DVDs, toys and books are based on these heroes, villains, and far-out stories which we, in the mighty Marvel bullpen, had so much fun creating. None of us could have suspected that our creations would become so famous that we'd one day find ourselves featured in a prestigious encyclopedia.

And, speaking of this extraordinary book, when it comes to finding the hero or villain you may be seeking, the publishers have made it as easy for you as recognizing the Hulk in a crowd.

They've put the names of each and every one in convenient alphabetical order.

Starting with the creation of the "Fantastic Four," the world's greatest comic book (as we so modestly called it), you'll also be able to find decade-by-decade highlights from Marvel's fabulous comic book history.

But what about the artwork? Glad you asked! You'll find illustrations from the very best of Marvel's amazing army of artists, pencilers and inkers who have made their indelible marks on the consciousness of comic book fans worldwide.

And, naturally, the accompanying texts are written by the most acclaimed scriptwriters in Marvel's galaxy of gifted scribes. Every sentence is a tribute to the greatest Super Hero creations this side of Asgard.

But that's not all. Realizing that some of the spectacular characters in our Super Hero stable have actually achieved such status and fame that they are now truly worldwide legends, the editors have wisely decided to accord these special heroes and villains full-page, double-page, or even *two* double-page layouts, plus a brief guide to their essential storylines.

There's so much more that I could say, but if I do it'll keep me from leaving my computer and reaching for my beautiful, brand-new Marvel Encyclopedia which is proudly sitting on my corner table. It might be my imagination, but I seem to see a glow around that voluminous volume, as though it's illuminated by some supernatural aura, some mystic radiance emanating from the combined power of the fantastic characters within its pages.

I know I must be fantasizing, and yet—as I slowly reach out to touch the cover of this magnificent book, I wonder—as you may wonder, too—what magic lies within?

Excelsior!

Stan

